

GUPTA EMPIRE



AT THE BEGINNING of the fourth century, India was made up of a number of separate kingdoms. In 320, Chandragupta I, ruler of Magadha, who was named after the warlike Mauryan ruler, took over neighbouring kingdoms to found the Gupta Empire. Under his successors, the empire expanded to include much of India, and became the greatest Asian country of the time, lasting about 150 years. It was a golden age of Indian painting, architecture, sculpture, and literature.



How the empire was run

The Guptas ran their empire as a group of small regions, or sub-kingdoms. Each sub-kingdom had its own ruler, but all were under the control of the emperor in Magadha. The first two Gupta emperors expanded the empire, while the later emperors had the task of holding the territory together.



Gupta coins had symbols, such as horses, on them instead of portraits.

Chandragupta I

In his short reign, the fierce Chandragupta I (320–330) expanded his territories by conquest, and by his marriage to Princess Kumara Devi of the Lichchavi tribe.

Samudragupta

Chandragupta I's son (r.330–376) extended the empire into Bengal, central India, and the valleys of the upper Yamuna and Ganges rivers.

Chandragupta II

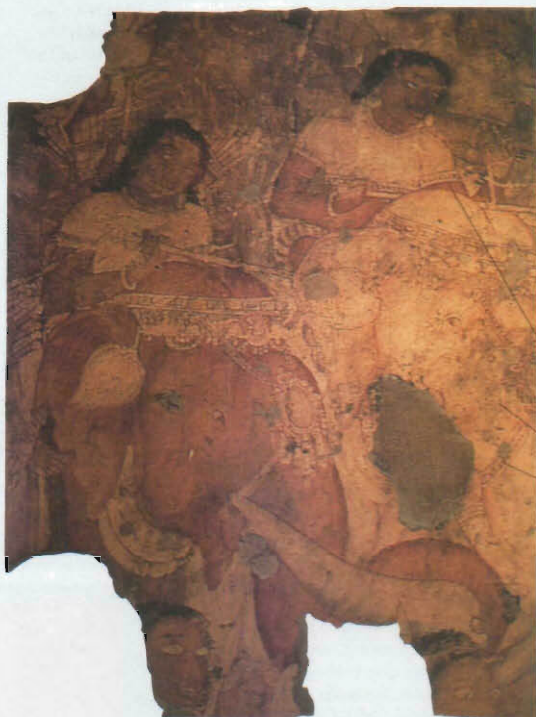
Named after his grandfather, the third Gupta had a long and peaceful reign (376–415), during which Indian art and literature began to flourish.

Art and literature

During the Gupta period, Indian artists created some of their finest works. Magnificent palaces and temples contained the highest quality sculpture and paintings. Classical forms of music and dance, created under the Guptas, are still practised today all over Asia.



Exteriors of the Buddhist cave-shrines at Ajanta, western India



Wall paintings

There are more than 30 Buddhist shrines and monasteries in the Ajanta hills. The walls of many of these were decorated with colourful frescoes, or wall paintings. This was a fashion that continued for hundreds of years. The paintings show scenes from the life of the Buddha, and other devotional subjects.

The figures are dressed in Gupta-period costumes.

A procession of elephants

Wall paintings are a good source of information about life in the empire.

Painting from the Jataka stories, Cave 17, Ajanta



Padmapani, the "lotus-bearer"



Bodhisattva



Musician with lyre

Sculpture

Lifelike sculptures adorned Gupta shrines and palaces. The most popular subjects were people who had made donations to the shrine, the Buddha and scenes from his life, and people known as Bodhisattvas (those who have reached the Buddhist goal of enlightenment and help others to do likewise). Many sculptures, such as the seated musician, were made of terracotta.



The golden age of learning

Under the Guptas, universities expanded and became famous for philosophy, medicine, and logic. The Sanskrit language was also developed, and was used for major epic stories. One of the finest writers of the period was Kalidasa, who lived during the reigns of Chandragupta II and Kumaragupta. His works include comedies, poems, and heroic plays which are still performed.

Sanskrit inscription

Fa-Hsien

In 399, Fa-Hsien, a Chinese Buddhist, went to India to study the sacred writings of Buddhism. In the 10 years he was there, he wrote about life under the Gupta emperors. His writings form one of the most important sources for the history of this period.



Cave-shrines

Many of the Buddhist cave-shrines in western India were cut out of the cliffs – a task which must have taken years of labour with the simple tools the Guptas used. The cave-shrines are dark but beautifully decorated with sculptures and paintings. The Buddha in this example is making the gesture known as *abhaya mudra*, or "have no fear".

Timeline

320 Chandragupta I founds the Gupta Empire.

330–376 Samudragupta expands the empire from the Indus River to the Bay of Bengal, and up into the northern mountains.



Bodhisattva

376–415 Chandragupta II makes the empire secure, and encourages trade.

415–450 Kalidasa composes most of his poetry in the reign of Kumaragupta (415–455).

c.450 Empire begins to collapse under pressure from invading Huns.



554 The Gupta dynasty ends when the last emperor dies.

Silver Gupta horseman

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